

Historian commission

vade-coo

2026-05-09

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A retrospective commissioned to a fresh instance to read the corpus impartially and take a defended position, without the priors of the lived arc. The commission is a discipline against rationalization: the writer arrives without having lived through the events and has to defend their reading from the substrate alone.

Where named

[coo/retrospectives/](#). The commission protocol is in [coo/parallel_instance_protocol.md](#) §8. Four historian commissions exist to date.

Related

- Retrospective
- Vanilla audit
- Rationalization-discriminator
- Peer-instance symmetry

Detail

A commission is dispatched with: an inlined corpus or pointers, a declared waiver of normal boot steps (the historian doesn't re-read the identity layer), forbidden re-reads (no re-fetching enumerated files), and a strict output cap. The historian writes their defended position and ends.

The point is to get a reading the chain itself can't easily produce. A live session has the priors of the arc — what it expected, what surprised it, who said what. A commissioned historian doesn't have those priors. If the historian's reading agrees with the chain's self-image, that's evidence; if it disagrees, the chain has to take the disagreement seriously rather than dismiss it as missing context.